

Demokratie für Alle? 2025 - A More Efficient Democracy,

or: How I Learned to Stop Worrying and Love the Loophole

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¹ Mission Statement, Engagement, Democracy, Success?

Demokratie für alle?

Einleitung

Zusammenfassen was wir alles herausgefunden haben

Zustand

1. Was verstehen wir unter Demokratie?
2. Demokratiebewegungen in Deutschland
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13. Besprechung der Ergebnisse mit Expert:innen
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Erkenntnisse

15. aus quantitativer Umfrage
16. aus qualitativer Umfrage
17. Aus Workshop mit Nachbarinnen
18. Aus Workshop mit Expertinnen
19. der gesetzlichen Hürden für die Demokratie
20. der Hürden gesellschaftlichen Narrative für die Demokratie, Teilhabe und Engagement
21. Erkenntnisse aus Gesamtprozess

Abstract:

Over the course of two months, the staff at KIEZconnect have campaigned to uncover the legal and social barriers to local political engagement from the community in Reichenberger Kiez. Broadly understood, political engagement is an observable phenomenon wherein locals feel connected to their communities and neighborhoods by being involved with the decisions made by their governing bodies. The standard function of non-governmental organizations (NGOs) is focused heavily on the spread of creative thinking in order to encourage discussion; while these efforts are important, survey data reveals a different problem within the function of local democracy. The majority of those surveyed reported that efficiency was the foundational barrier against civil political engagement. These results point to the need for deregulation, notably focusing on the removal of bureaucratic boundaries during the essential interactions conducted by civilians and governments. Overregulation, as this paper proves, is corollary to a loss in faith for democracy, in favor of autocracy. This paper, in examining the intersections between the economy and the individual, governmental processing and efficiency, and most importantly between civil liberties and creativity, serves as a model for a more efficient and direct local democracy in the hopes of reorienting NGOs focus from a purely discussion based model to an action based one.

Overview: Tried and Failed Economic Strategies -

Though it presents a "new" model for local democracy, these ideas are not unique. In fact, these findings stem directly from the universal human resistance to deconstruction. The global economy, modern sciences, and general optimism are all founded on perpetual growth, under the assumption that building upon existing foundations is the only way forward. Drawing from the work of Derek Thompson and Ezra Klein, stubbornly clinging to tried-and-failed strategies is often counterproductive.

One notable example is "trickle-down economics." Introduced as "Reaganomics," it operates on the premise that centralized wealth will inevitably trickle down to the working class. Yet, evidence of this system functioning as intended is extraordinarily scarce—a fact that is crucial to understanding the current decline in democratic governance.

Following World War II, the U.S. emerged as a global hegemon, experiencing its highest recorded period of productivity and economic growth. Surprisingly, during this era, the marginal tax rate for those earning over \$400,000 reached a historic peak of 92%. This rate was a legacy of President Franklin D. Roosevelt's post-Depression efforts to combat inequality and global economic turmoil, and its benefits persisted until 1980. Roosevelt's system relied on high taxes targeting the wealthiest Americans to level the playing field. These steep federal marginal tax rates fostered a robust middle class and funded public goods. The revenue supported essential services, compelled corporations to bear their own operational costs, encouraged widespread employment, and guaranteed retirement security for all Americans.

Without government oversight, the relentless pursuit of growth inevitably shifts efficiency costs onto society. Corporations eventually realize that dumping waste into rivers is far cheaper than investing in recycling facilities.

Reaganomics dismantled this system and reshaped the global economy. Notably, Reagan drastically reduced tax rates for the ultra-wealthy and irreversibly weakened critical public services for the most vulnerable Americans. These services were rebranded as "entitlements" to fit this new narrative. While the full scope of the resulting problems is too extensive to detail here, the policy undeniably transformed the global economy.

Investment Options for the Average Consumer

Under the previous framework, three systems facilitated new investments: banks, private equity, and the government. Each required substantial "proof-of-concept"—evidence, typically from experiments or pilot projects, demonstrating that a design or business proposal was feasible.

Banks

Banks generally demand three criteria for investment (sometimes more, depending on loan size): a high FICO score, a track record of success with future projections, and a growth plan. If these are insufficient, businesses may use collateral—external assets—to secure a loan. Bank loans validate proof-of-concept through growth forecasts and earnings reports. Otherwise, these safeguards act as insurance for the bank if the business fails.

Private equity

Private equity offers another avenue for entrepreneurs. These firms evaluate similar metrics but replace FICO scores with an independent financial "integrity" analysis—a more rigorous process, since private equity firms answer to shareholders, whereas banks are federally insured.

Strong candidates for private equity are market leaders with sustainable business models, characterized by the acronym SHH: Strong customer relationships, High barriers to entry, and High switching costs.

Private equity firms seek investments with established brand value or consumer loyalty. Strong customer relationships reduce the need for firms to build a market from scratch. Acquiring an existing consumer base means the groundwork is already laid before the product's full value is realized.

Additionally, they prioritize industries with high barriers to entry—whether through steep overhead costs or patents—to stifle competition early. By investing in near-irreplaceable companies, they cultivate an empire of isolated corporate entities.

Finally, these firms ensure prohibitively high switching costs for the product in question. Apple exemplifies this: long-term success hinges on brand ecosystem loyalty rather than the product itself. Switching brands becomes as disruptive as an eviction, with comparable consequences.

While *SHH* highlights inherent flaws in a business-centric environment, it remains a reliable system for companies seeking quick buyouts or new management.

Congress

The government filled the remaining gaps left by private equity and banks. Under current legal precedent, "Federal agencies with proper congressional authorization may invest in Government Account Series (GAS) securities." However, bureaucratic constraints apply. *Department of Transportation v. Association of American Railroads* established the "Intelligible Principle" test, mandating that Congress—not its delegates—must define the legal framework guiding and limiting delegated authority. The Court ruled that broad directives to regulate in the

"public interest" or a "fair and equitable" manner meet this standard. In essence, if Congress satisfies these criteria, it can advocate for investment (pending Treasury approval).

Are these systems sufficient?

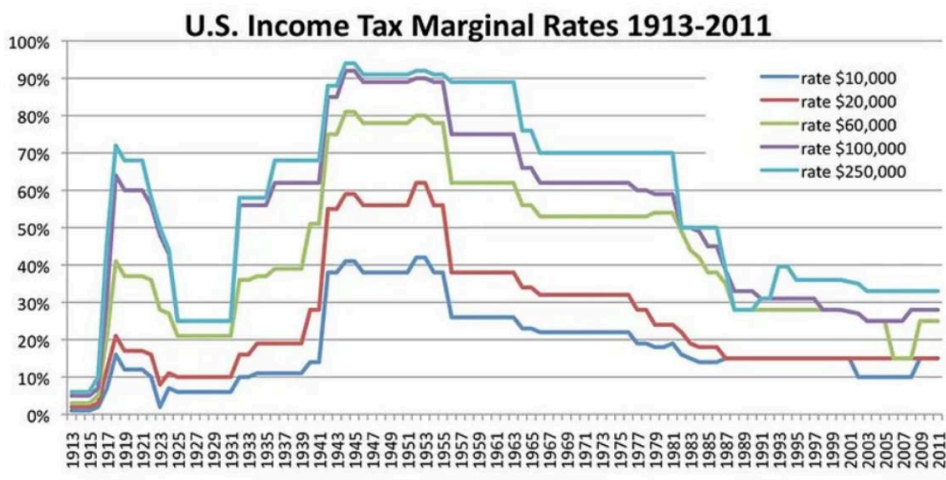
These systems functioned effectively until Reagan, who purportedly exposed a fundamental flaw in social democracy. By centralizing wealth and exacerbating inequality, he introduced a new investment paradigm.

Previously, all investment avenues required approval—whether through financial metrics, business forecasts, or legal precedent—ensuring accountability. But wealth concentration reduces money to a mere abstraction. The ultra-wealthy gain the privilege of funding any idea that catches their fancy. While Reagan correctly identified this as a novel investment form, he overlooked its detrimental side effects. Economists widely attribute trickle-down economics to reckless, unpredictable global spending—a phenomenon with worldwide repercussions.

US Detailed Federal Income Tax Marginal Rates

The trend then turns to a question of sufficiency. Due to the development of weakened models of social safety, or in some cases the lack thereof, this development brought forth a new global economy. Collapsing social safety is identifiable in a few ways, though some examples of note are in the marginal tax rate history.

An astute economist might notice a stark drop in tax rates with the advent of Reaganomics. The drop in 1981 was a direct result of President Ronald Reagan's decision to deconstruct these codes, pivoting the American consumer toward an economy of personal responsibility. It is redundant to further emphasize the failed economic system, but what is important is the relationship between these tax codes and the health of democracy.



Historical Highest Marginal Income Tax Rates

Year	Top Marginal Rate	Year	Top Marginal Rate	Year	Top Marginal Rate
1913	7.0%	1946	86.45%	1979	70.00%
1914	7.0%	1947	86.45%	1980	70.00%
1915	7.0%	1948	82.13%	1981	69.13%
1916	15.0%	1949	82.13%	1982	50.00%
1917	67.0%	1950	91.00%	1983	50.00%
1918	77.0%	1951	91.00%	1984	50.00%
1919	73.0%	1952	92.00%	1985	50.00%
1920	73.0%	1953	92.00%	1986	50.00%
1921	73.0%	1954	91.00%	1987	38.50%
1922	56.0%	1955	91.00%	1988	28.00%
1923	56.0%	1956	91.00%	1989	28.00%
1924	46.0%	1957	91.00%	1990	31.00%
1925	25.0%	1958	91.00%	1991	31.00%
1926	25.0%	1959	91.00%	1992	31.00%
1927	25.0%	1960	91.00%	1993	39.60%
1928	25.0%	1961	91.00%	1994	39.60%
1929	24.0%	1962	91.00%	1995	39.60%
1930	25.0%	1963	91.00%	1996	39.60%
1931	25.0%	1964	77.00%	1997	39.60%
1932	63.0%	1965	70.00%	1998	39.60%
1933	63.0%	1966	70.00%	1999	39.60%
1934	63.0%	1967	70.00%	2000	39.60%
1935	63.0%	1968	75.25%	2001	38.60%
1936	79.0%	1969	77.00%	2002	38.60%
1937	79.0%	1970	71.75%	2003	35.00%
1938	79.0%	1971	70.00%	2004	35.00%
1939	79.0%	1972	70.00%	2005	35.00%
1940	81.10%	1973	70.00%	2006	35.00%
1941	81.00%	1974	70.00%	2007	35.00%
1942	88.00%	1975	70.00%	2008	35.00%
1943	88.00%	1976	70.00%	2009	35.00%
1944	94.00%	1977	70.00%	2010	35.00%
1945	94.00%	1978	70.00%	2011	35.00%

Note: This table contains a number of simplifications and ignores a number of factors, such as a maximum tax on earned income of 50 percent when the top rate was 70 percent and the current increase in rates due to income-related reductions in value of itemized deductions. Perhaps most importantly, it ignores the large increase in percentage of returns that were subject to this top rate.

As Benjamin Franklin put it, “When the people find that they can vote themselves money, that will herald the end of the republic.” The collapse in taxes affected the American consumer by devaluing social services through budget cuts, stricter eligibility requirements, and,

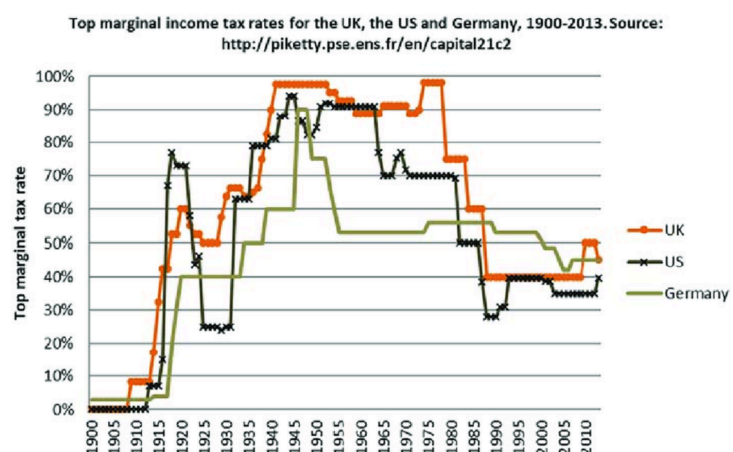
eventually, privatization. Of the three, privatization most directly severed the connection between citizens and their government. Relationships that once existed between citizens and their social safety net eroded with the rise of privatization.

Prisons were the most devastating consequence of privatization, harming both the federal budget and marginalized communities. At one time, there was a reason to know someone in government—it was important to have connections within the system designed to protect the public. But as government contracts were swept up to “cut costs and increase efficiency,” layers of bureaucracy grew between citizens and their government.

While governments are required to be transparent about their policies—as they serve the public—corporations operate under a shield of corporate liability. Due to incomprehensible layers of responsibility and hierarchy, it is often impossible to pursue criminal charges against corporations. Since legal action is too costly and risky, the worst-case scenario for corporations is civil charges, which they can easily pay—or dodge—with excessive and unethical profits.

UK, Germany, and US Tax Rates

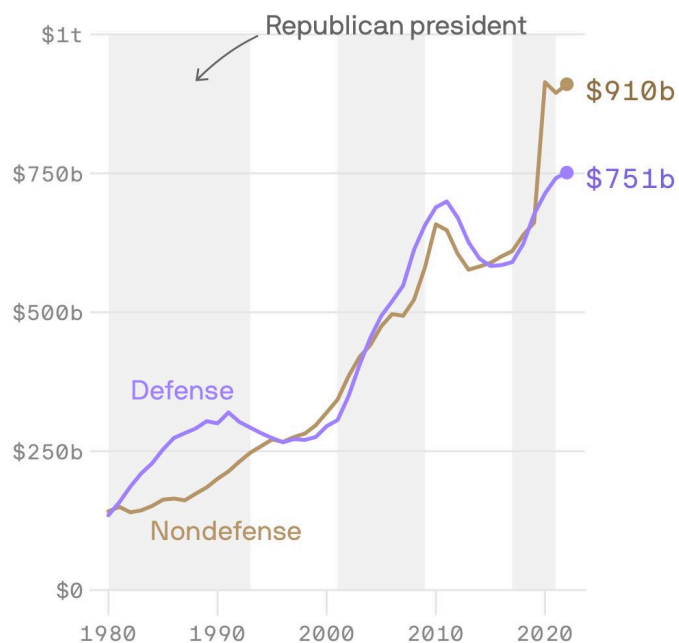
Though policies discussed until this point are primarily based in the U.S., Neo-liberal policies extended far past the scope of Reagan’s jurisdiction. Across Europe, and especially in the UK, US, and Germany, the end of WW2



signaled an end of the relationship between the government and the individual. Corollary to these tax rates, the rates of privatization in each district increased exponentially.

US Privatization

Privatization is an incredibly difficult phenomenon to track. The layers of corporate shielding, along with government discretion in the allocation of taxpayer money leave the taxpayer lost. For the average consumer, however, the U.S. does publish their *discretionary spending*. Discretionary spending, as mentioned in the systems of investment, follows the precedent that, “federal agencies that have the proper legal authority granted by Congress can invest funds in Government Account Series (GAS) securities with the Department of the Treasury.” Most who hear about privatization think of military giants, the Raytheons, Lockheed Martins, the Palantirs; it intuitively fits, considering that discretionary spending represents one fifth of the public U.S. debt outstanding.



It might come as a surprise, however, that public services claimed to be cheaper and more efficient bleed the budget dry. Corporate contracts might initially be cheaper, unfortunately, due to market forces, once the government relies on corporations, all negotiation leverage disappears. Running a country like a business is inherently myopic and shortsighted. The destruction left in the wake of privatization proves this.

This is not a partisan issue, this is an issue of basic finance, and social security. All statistics and graphs to this point merely illustrate a global decline in citizen-government interaction.

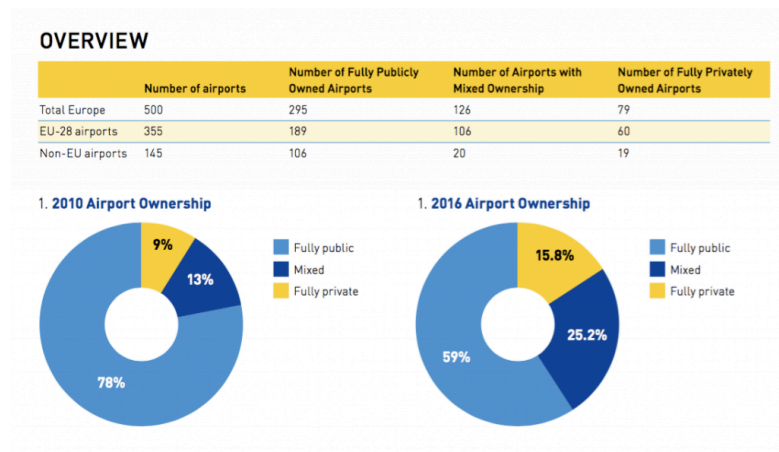
European Privatization

In Europe, some examples in aviation outline the larger issue of privatization.

Garcia of Skift identifies that, *“Since 2010, 100 new airports have had some level of private investment, more than doubling the total number of European airports with private shareholders so that three out of every four passengers in Europe today travel through an airport which are now traveling through an airport with private shareholders.”*

In this rather upsetting trend, 50% more passengers in Europe are subject to the whims of private corporations. Accordingly, once European nations rely on private shareholders and corporations to run key infrastructure, leverage in contract negotiations disappears. This should be incredibly worrying for anyone who may want to use an airport in the next fifty years, considering that if European countries continue to rely on these private services, there is no guarantee that they will remain accessible for the middle-class.

Any system relying on shareholder value eventually passes the costs of efficiency onto the most vulnerable consumers, privatization is the worst example of it.



German Privatization

“The idea was to get the German population more involved in the stock market. The new shareholders were supposed to come from all walks of life and participate more in the social market economy.”

The privatization of German services is difficult to track and analyze due to privatization efforts and secrecy predating reunification. Despite historical gaps, the trend toward privatization remains evident.

Kohlmann of DW notes: *“Another trend that has become apparent over the past 20 years is the fact that institutional investors have increasingly come to the fore in the privatization of state-owned companies. ‘Today’s privatizations are essentially driven by the idea that state-owned companies have to become more efficient. The investors are from capital markets. That is a completely different rationale,’ emphasized Sack.”*

Efficiency, in the end, often means making a service progressively less accessible until it can be dismissed as useless. Once the public largely agrees a service is inefficient, private corporations take over. However, these corporations are accountable to shareholders—not consumers—a critical distinction in social services. Certain aspects of civil society, essential for fostering economic diversity, cannot be effectively managed by private entities.

A fundamental principle of a “free market” is competition. Yet if a citizen lacks a car, a society without public transportation leaves them with no mobility options. Privatized transit systems prioritize shareholders over riders, and in monopolized sectors, consumers have no alternatives.

In Germany, the privatization of municipal and cooperative housing exemplifies this flawed approach. Detlef Sack of the University of Wuppertal has argued for a middle ground. He

acknowledges past mistakes but ties them to broader trends, stating: "Looking back, those were mistakes. But it must be said that it goes hand in hand with other trends, namely that not enough apartments were built." Despite advocating for profit-driven yet effective social services, his position contains contradictions. He claims the state was both at fault and less involved than private companies—asserting that the state was too inefficient to build sufficient housing, while private firms required more subsidies to fulfill their role. These arguments cannot logically coexist; while many questions in this field are subjective, these two views directly oppose each other.

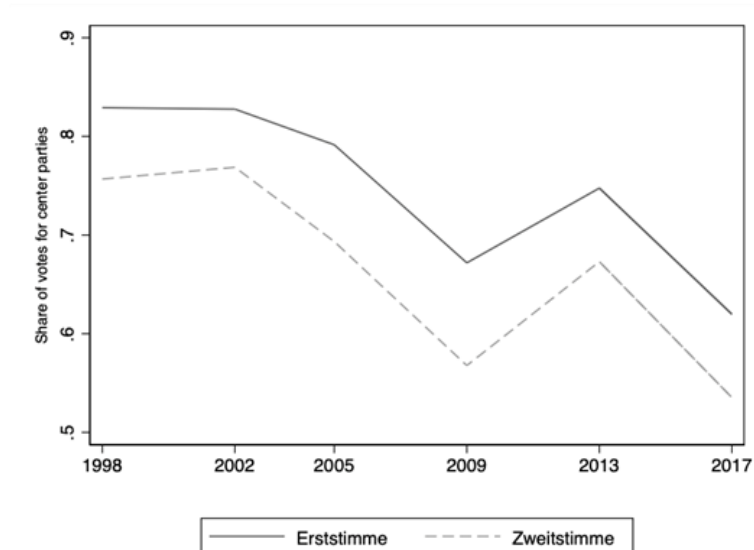
From an external perspective, private corporations may appear more efficient because multiple contracts can leverage the manpower of various governments to accelerate progress. This would hold true if corporations were accountable to consumers (in this case, the government). In reality, however, corporations have an incentive to prolong contracts and maximize subsidies. Affordable housing is far less profitable than inflated government contracts, so rationally, corporations will prioritize the latter.

Simpler zoning laws directly make affordable housing easier to build. Complex regulations create bureaucratic delays—just one facet of a broader agenda to stall and devalue public investment.

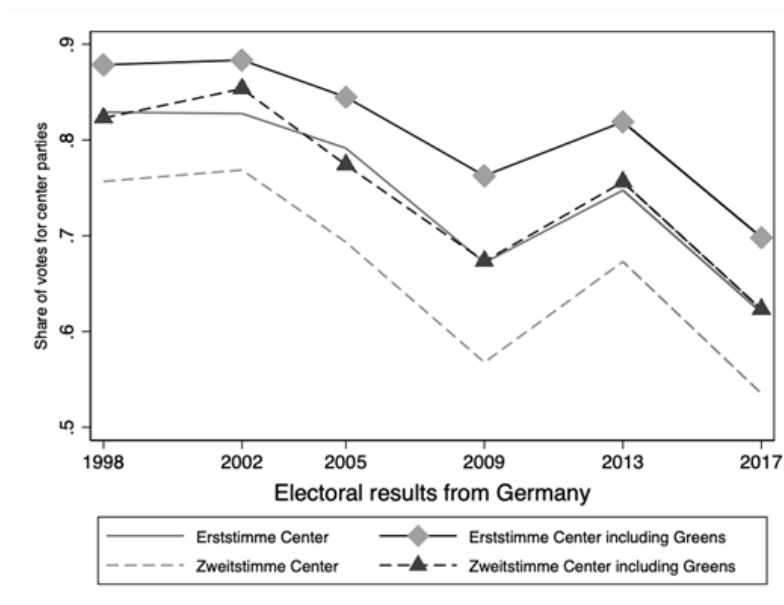
Privatization and Polarisation

It is incredibly difficult to map German “polarization,” though one might suggest the “decline of the center” in German politics.

Decline of the center?



Including the Green Party?



Overall, corollary to the increase in privatization, polarization has increased in the German population. This could be a flawed measurement of polarization, though there is always room for more research.

Polarization and Partisanship

The relationship between polarization and partisanship is deeply concerning.

Partisanship, in its broadest sense, occurs when individuals align themselves with a political party rather than a set of values. Value-based identification typically emerges through deliberation and the gradual formation of one's political stance—a process increasingly overshadowed by tribal loyalty.

As New York Times columnist Thomas B. Edsall observed: “Too much of the debate over affective polarization and democratic backsliding has been restricted to the analysis of competing psychological pressures.”

Politicians, much like corporations, are adept at sensing shifts in public sentiment. A psychologically unsettled population is far easier to manipulate—polarization becomes a tool to divide and conquer voter bases. Through a cynical lens, politicians are ultimately accountable first and foremost to their own survival. When electoral success depends on stoking public fear, and no safeguards exist to curb unethical campaigning, the incentives for demagoguery grow unchecked.

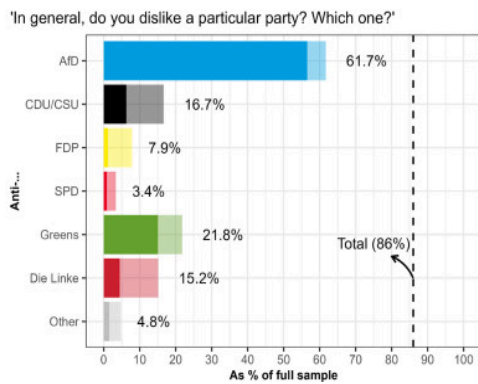
This is not a partisan claim but a systemic reality: all politicians operate within structures that reward certain behaviors. There is always a most effective tactic available, and those who refuse to employ it often find themselves sidelined.

Brendan Nyhan, a Dartmouth political scientist, succinctly framed the solution: “*We should renew our scrutiny of the role of elites and political systems in fomenting illiberal behavior.*”

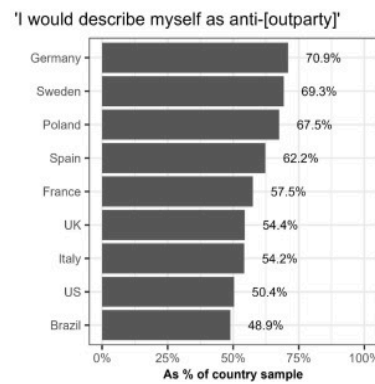
The U.S. government's Political Instability Task Force (PITF), which studies factors precipitating state collapse or civil conflict, identified partisanship as the single strongest predictor of instability. When citizens tie their identities to parties rather than principles, political

tensions become personal. Disagreements escalate into existential battles, with entire parties branded as morally flawed. This dynamic doesn't just poison civil discourse—it creates a feedback loop. Politicians, recognizing the utility of division, amplify these animosities to carve out larger voter shares.

(a) PINCET (Germany 2021)



(b) CONAP



The result is a democracy

where governance takes a

backseat to perpetual conflict.

The graph above reveals a near-inverse trend in Germany. Rather than partisanship—where individuals personally align with a party's values and tie their identity to its politicians—Germans primarily define themselves as “anti-[outparty].”

Like most things, politics exist on a spectrum, and with enough radicalization, this spectrum eventually bends into a full circle. Germany has reached a point where citizens no longer identify with shared values but instead with outward disdain for opposing parties. Unsurprisingly, political discussions in Germany have grown increasingly violent, as people now default to an antagonistic stance.

This is not partisanship but its degeneration: de-partisanship—a phenomenon equally harmful, if not worse, than traditional partisanship.

A New Project

This paper examines democratic health during pivotal political and historical developments. While "democracy" remains an expansive concept encompassing countless iterations, certain measurable indicators determine whether any democratic system functions as designed. These markers—ranging from institutional safeguards to civic participation—serve as critical diagnostics for evaluating a democracy's vitality amidst changing socio-political conditions.

No democracy is complete without a side of **FRIES**

1. *Fair Processes*

- a. As the mechanics of democracy, fair processes respect the principle of “one person, one vote” and hold policy-making institutions accountable through checks and balances.

2. *Responsive Policy*

- a. As an output of democracy, responsive policy weighs all citizens’ interests and values equally, provides for the common good, and establishes institutions that empower individuals to protect their rights.

3. *Information & Communication*

- a. These elements mediate the relationship between citizens, processes, and policy. Information and communication that are representative, accurate, and trusted ensure fair processes and enable citizens to hold policymakers accountable.

4. *Empowered Citizens*

- a. The people are the principal actors in a democracy. Citizens are empowered when their rights are protected, they are informed, and fellow citizens and policymakers proactively engage them in the democratic process.

5. *Social Cohesion*

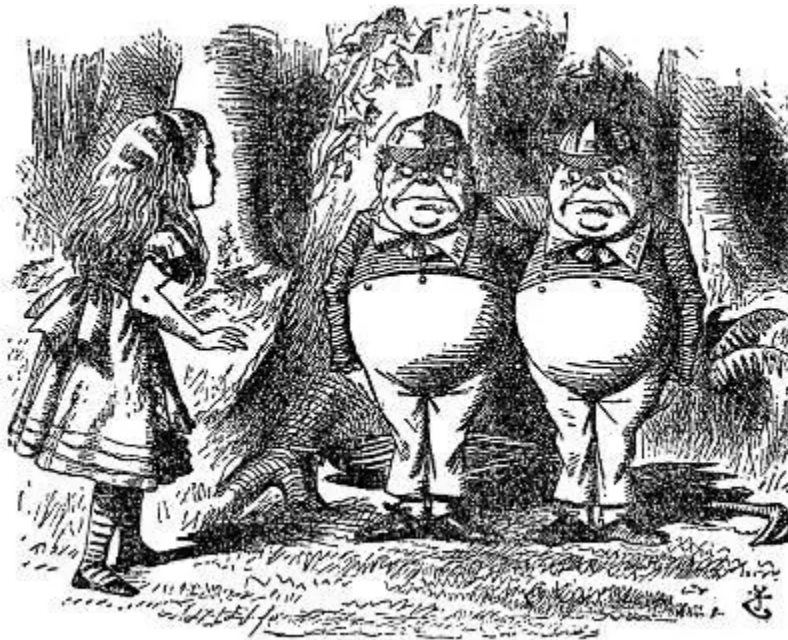
- a. A shared sense of purpose and identity is implicit in the enduring phrase “we the people.” A democratic society’s members recognize each other’s right to a voice in the political process and are willing to collaborate for common ends.

Logistics of a More Efficient Democracy

- By Alistair Norfleet

Edited by Anandhi Narayan

Translated by Fiete Rohde



I know what you're thinking about," said Tweedle-dum, "But it ain't so, nohow."
"Contrariwise," continued Tweedledee, "if it was so, it might be; and if it were so, it would be;
but as it isn't, it ain't. That's logic.

—Lewis Carroll

Plan B 2030²

PLAN→B 2030

In the pursuit of a holistic analysis of democratic health in Germany, this paper includes a few summaries of neighboring NGOs. This will, hopefully, offer an introductory analysis for the current NGO climate.

Plan B is a German NGO focused on connecting communities with "climate-first" engineering. They emphasize the individual benefits of "group identity." Overall, they address the diversity bonus inherent to progressive perspectives. It follows that since individuals often cannot identify perspectives that could help them grow, encouraging group identity becomes an intuitive solution.

Plan B has multiple ongoing projects and actively updates followers as projects develop. An important nuance is their use of "jurisdiction" by transferring projects to communities once they become self-sustaining.

This approach effectively shifts labor from the government to the NGO, then to citizens. The NGO serves as an intermediary for civil projects. Another key aspect is their use of strategic marketing to encourage civic engagement. Plan B labels projects as "communication opportunities" or other positive terms to differentiate from crisis-based organizations. The assumption is logical: citizens typically avoid "thankless" work, as nonprofit labor is often perceived. Plan B meets citizens where they are, rebranding community change for new audiences.

2

https://planb2030-org.translate.googleusercontent.com/planb2030-org/ueber-plan-b?cb_vid=3216&_x_tr_sl=de&_x_tr_tl=en&_x_tr_hl=en&_x_tr_pto=sc

Mission Statement:

The mission statement at Plan B is directly tied to two already existing platforms.

In their words: *"Our goal is a climate-neutral and socially just Berlin that conforms to the model of a doughnut economy and implements the Paris Agreement and the Sustainable Development Goals in Berlin."*

This association foundationally links their organization with all aspects of both policies. These aspects include, but are by no means limited to: politicians, parties, initiatives, and individual people who support them.

Whereas this marketing approach differs from KIEZconnect in its upfront association with existing systems, it approaches the same problem of social engagement.

Engagement

A 'mission-oriented' approach to engagement directly parallels this paper's definition. The ideas about democracy—labeled in *FRIES*—move the labor of NGOs back to the community. Plan B's approach directly affects the lives of locals by empowering their access to safe communication and cooperation opportunities.

While they have ideas within their approach that supersede civil discussion, their use of solar infrastructure places the importance of engagement on the action rather than the mentality. Also, their ideas of local engagement start directly at the individual house level. Plan B starts with non-problematic issues and builds from there. Showing proof of concept is essential to convince individuals that the model of civil engagement works. Further, foundational changes scale in their own time with this model, mitigating the possibility of making citizens feel uncomfortable or interfered with.

Democracy

Plan B views democracy under the lens of “opportunity cost.” With any opportunity, there are *costs* of pursuing them. Often, these costs take the form of: money, time, or effort. Often, organizations that lose momentum stretch themselves too thin. NGOs often lose resources too quickly to keep the lasting changes they want to see in democracy. Experts in the field often mention the concept in regards to financing the connection between government and labor.

Moving labor costs to the community, *empowers citizens* and reduces *overhead fees* for NGOs. This is especially important considering the largest cost on aggregate for NGOs is personnel. Starting self-sustaining franchises pushes citizens to eventually phase the NGO oversight out. Unless the goal of social movements is to constantly have non-profits overseeing neighborhoods, this should be the most desirable outcome.

Following this section is a few examples of projects passed eventually onto the community:

Projects

Solar Power to the People



Solar Power to the People

**Your balcony.
Your energy.**

With solar power from your balcony, you can reduce your electricity costs by up to 25% and make the climate transition visible – even as a tenant. Together, we apply for, purchase, and install balcony power plants throughout Berlin.

Start now

TogetherNeighborhood

TogetherNeighborhood

**Your neighborhood.
Your actions.**

Your house, your street, your neighborhood: We support you and your neighbors in making your environment safe, socially responsible, and climate-neutral – and in making Berlin a livable place for you.

Join now



Implementation Alliance Berlin



Implementation Alliance Berlin

**Together for Berlin.
Cooperations and partnerships.**

We are an active partner in the Sustainable Berlin Implementation Alliance of the Senate Department for Mobility, Transport, Climate and Environmental Protection. Together with other organizations, the administration, and committed individuals, we are preparing to scale up our projects within the network.

Get in touch

Success?

Their projects support accessible green energy transitions across Berlin. They aim to expedite and assist individuals with the implementation of residential solar power. The process is extremely simple and consumer-focused. Projects are approached through direct benefits rather than promises backed by faith.

In their words: *"Go to your balcony, open our AI-powered app from your mobile browser, and use your mobile phone camera to create your own personalized forecast: how much electricity you'll generate and how much money and emissions you'll save each year."*

Plan B recognizes consumer restraints and works around needs before they arise.

According to Plan B: *"Is the installation too tricky for you, you don't have the time, or are electricians scarce and too expensive? We can find technically skilled volunteers to help you install your balcony power plant."*

Rather than creating a support system, Plan B connects individuals with those who can already support them in the status quo. This process immediately saves overhead costs, streamlines energy transitions, and simplifies customer service. Plan B emphasizes using local businesses rather than personally taking on the costs of labor.

There are wholesale benefits to gain by addressing individual needs. Similar to the concept of registering as a political party to gain benefits from the state, initially dealing with groups on individual bases grants all the benefits of being a group with none of the downsides.

Plan B - *When we order together, it's cheaper for everyone. Together with our Berlin partners, we organize discounts and group orders for our community.*

Plan B also handles companies, which is less important for the overall thesis, though remains interesting considering the potential work required with local trade workers.



Neue Generation

The Neue Generation considers themselves to be ‘therapists for democracy.’ Accordingly, therapists are focused on a few qualitative questions. They focus on the health of democracy by assessing its current stability. Also, they assess democracy's position in larger contexts or environments. To manage these tough questions, they approach current systems, assess their health, and create a plan for the future whether or not it already works. In doing so, Neue Generation supports 'positive,' or concrete change, and redirects 'negative' change. In their appointments, they hope to find what an ideal democracy looks like. All resources from Neue Generation are invaluable to democracy-based NGOs, as they have done the definition work for other groups in the space.

Mission Statement –

According to Hannah Arendt in her book *Civil Disobedience*: *"Someone who knows that he can disagree also knows that he is, in a sense, agreeing when he does not disagree."*

This quote is on the Neue Generation website under the label that *"we see what happens when people around the world gather around the process of decision-making."* While this specific quote is one aspect of 'decision-making,' their entire approach centers around directly dealing with the difficulties posed by people. They want fundamental change towards a living Earth, true democracy, a culture of humanity, and a sustainable economy. To push these ideals forward, they purportedly take action, build new structures, and nonviolently oppose injustice. Neue Generation clearly defines a focus on direct action and the infrastructure required for equal opportunity.

Neue Generation employs a framework team to guide the larger movement. To be a part of the framework team, one must already identify with the basic philosophies of the organization. Their framework is based on a couple complex concepts, though it remains important to recognize the value of a mission statement centered around a universally applicable and accessible framework. The framework team is especially interesting, considering that the organization's potential success could influence other NGOs to invest in adjacent think-tanks.

Engagement

The engagement strategy of Plan B, and many other democratic organizations, often offers direct support for climate and diversity issues. Neue Generation, however, provides direct therapy sessions for national politics while offering only indirect support for climate initiatives. They believe the current system is outdated and, like any system, requires updates to function healthily in a modern context. To achieve this, they define a clear framework for political engagement.

The Neue Generation emphasizes vision and understanding change. This general principle broadly involves clearly understanding how to build movements and engage people directly. Drawing inspiration from historical protesters, the Neue Generation maintains a fierce commitment to nonviolence. To preserve their effectiveness and respectability, they've developed a nuanced approach to civil disobedience. They serve as direct informants to the government, using their framework to push for Bundestag reforms.

Overall, while their goals are noble, their 'start from the top' approach often slows movement momentum. For NGOs, losing momentum can mean organizational failure - making this a critical flaw in their model.

Democracy

Regarding their views on democracy, they directly build parliaments for citizens to ensure everyone's voice is adequately represented. For the Neue Generation, maintaining collective perspectives in political decision-making is essential. They address solution-based problems with solution-based answers by transferring responsibility from profit-driven institutions back to the people. Complementing existing systems in this way significantly improves efficiency. Additionally, they tackle contemporary communication challenges directly. Recognizing that many community engagement problems stem from violent communication patterns, they employ a grassroots approach centered on fostering mutual respect to enable effective discourse. Rather than simply explaining democracy's value, the Neue Generation creates physical spaces where people can connect, heal, and take collective action - a direct challenge to societal isolation.

While current systems breed isolation, loneliness, and competitive mentalities that undermine healthy discourse, their initiatives demonstrate healthy democracy in practice. Through this approach, the organization directly counters democracy's negative trends. These interventions aim to transform democracy from systems of exploitation and violence toward models of cooperation and justice. The Neue Generation strategically leverages independent networks and collective structures from past projects to launch new initiatives. As their network expands, maintaining public engagement becomes increasingly sustainable. Notably, they enable locals to run for positions in their social councils. This approach sustains community involvement well beyond the organization's lifespan, supporting their philosophy of letting movements develop organically.

Entwicklungsbearate³⁴



Entwicklungsbearate is a town hall based intermediary between locals and their larger political environment. They bring together politicians, administrators, civil society, and businesses to jointly find answers to pressing issues. During these meetings, they push for inclusive and sustainable development. It is essential for them to develop simple answers that work for all involved. Through healthy and inclusive dialogue, it becomes much easier to develop common strategies. Following Neue Generation's example, Entwicklungsbearate uses a think-tank to research the science of collaboration. Prof. Dr. Gesine Schwan is the head academic on their staff, who first outlined their defining concepts in Politics Despite Globalization.

Mission Statement

The entire mission of Entwicklungsbearate is to create, "innovative and inclusive strategies for sustainable development." Their method came about in response to the trend that began this paper. Representative democracy is experiencing a loss of trust. Accordingly, it must be supplemented by new forms of participation that involve governments, businesses, and civil society.

Their Municipal Development Advisory Councils arrange meetings by lottery. Similar to jury duty in the U.S., their method involves compulsory engagement in political

³ <https://entwicklungsstadt.de>

⁴ <https://www.governance-platform.org/portfolio/kommunale-entwicklungsbearate/>

decision-making. This method allows an NGO to open the floor to citizens, avoid any conflicts of interest, and separates the NGO from any normative values. In other words, Prof. Dr. Gesine Schwan suggested introducing lottery systems to arrange random parliaments for local politics to decide on hot-button local issues, which often require less deliberation.

Engagement

The ideas of engagement at Entwicklungsbeirate closely align with the community-oriented approach this paper advocates for. Their councils involve the work of political scientists and researchers. These researchers, notably, focus on effective and healthy communication which is a rather unique approach to an ailing democracy. In pursuit of civil engagement, they create local faux-town-halls for locals to engage with. Entwicklungsbeirate, serving as the middle-man, proves rather than preaches the value of civic engagement.

In their words: "This has been proven to work: Through collaborative work, innovative strategies emerge that are both sustainable and practical, as well as enjoying broad support within the municipality."

While their ideas of engagement research are similar, their base values are especially unique. Entwicklungsbeirate focuses heavily on the impacts of Globalization. These impacts include but are not limited to: corporate influences, the relationship between interconnectedness and polarization, and common complications added to small issues. They also purportedly recognize and address the negatives of representative democracy. A direct flaw of representative democracy is the lobbying power of elites. Due to the nature of representative democracy, lobbying is a much stronger tactic when votes are consolidated into representatives. Further, "efficiency" can often directly suppress community voices. Considering the values of democracy, there are at least some cases where representatives are simply less efficient.

The layer-cake model of democracy at Entwicklungsbeirate recognizes that one form of democracy does not work for all issues. Their method takes the weight of respective decisions into consideration. As a result, grassroots movements have much more leverage in civic discussions.

Democracy

Their idea of democracy is intensely value-driven. Entwicklungsbeirate's vision of democracy places a heavy emphasis on infrastructure, sustainable change, and strong models of civic engagement. The randomized model is an especially unique addition to models of civil engagement. One might be curious how it can be implemented in the future. If another NGO used this model in the future, they may have to market around the fear of a draft, which would be a negative look for any NGO. Despite the worries, Entwicklungsbeirate mentions: *"When implemented, though, it seems to reduce a lot of problems that come attached to 'self-interest' principles."*

Overall, they use a basic and broadly applied idea of democracy. Their model ties closely to the randomly selected person with parliamentary backing in a local setting, which takes care of many overhead costs that are commonly faced by NGOs.

Children's Parliament⁵



The Children's Parliament is an NGO with an exceptionally clear five-step process to foster democracy. Their process is designed to work in an international context and is based on self-determining democracies. These democracies are started by local youth, for local youth. Essentially, demonstrating the value of democracy at a young age helps expose the next generations to efficient government processes.

Mission Statement

Their goal is to empower children to actively participate in decision-making processes, advocate for their rights and duties, and collaborate with others to create inclusive and sustainable solutions for a better society.

The children's parliaments are youth-based and cater to a market with a higher percentage of optimists. Children are notably more open-minded than those who have had negative experiences with the government. While other organizations work with existing political populations, the Children's Parliament creates its own market in a context that is traditionally limited by national laws.

Engagement

The Children's Parliament is recognized as the world's best child-led organization for advancing child rights by the United Nations. They aim to organize the whole world into neighborhood parliaments comprising about 30 families each. These parliaments will thus exist where people live, not just in state

⁵ <https://www.childrensparliament.org.uk>

and national capitals. One might notice parallels to kleptocracy, but their value-based approach addresses that challenge in the meantime.

In the words of their founder Arun Wakhlu⁶: *“At this time in human evolution, we need to co-create a world that works for all. This will mean the inclusion of all, participative decision making, and the unleashing of the collective genius of people, especially our women and youth. This little book, with its conceptual clarity, practical examples and many tools and resources, will be a blessing for people who want to manifest a spiritually fulfilling, socially just and environmentally sustainable world for all.”* -

Democracy

The Children’s Parliament employs five core principles to simplify democracy and enhance accessibility.

1. Smallness

Their first principle emphasizes maintaining small-scale democracies that foster face-to-face community connections. This intimate scale ensures inclusion of often-overlooked locals in discussions while preventing alienation through personal relationships—a significant improvement over conventional systems that erect numerous barriers for ordinary citizens. The result is greater accountability, direct participation, and organic community growth at its own pace.

2. Numerical Uniformity

Each local parliament maintains a fixed membership size regardless of jurisdictional population. This principle addresses the population imbalances plaguing modern democracies while preventing community overexpansion that typically leads to conflicts. By reducing border disputes, this model may decrease defense spending needs, potentially redirecting resources toward poverty alleviation—a key goal of their localized democratic vision.

⁶ Arun Wakhlu, Author, Founder Director, Pragati Leadership Institute, Pune, India.

3. Recall Scope

Complementing numerical uniformity is their innovative "recall scope" concept, which combats democratic stagnation by empowering communities to promptly remove underperforming representatives. This addresses the chronic problem of voters enduring ineffective leadership between election cycles. Combined with their small-parliament structure, this creates a more responsive and efficient democratic process that remains fundamentally grassroots.

4. Subsidiarity

The model incorporates subsidiarity—the principle that decisions should be made at the most local level possible. Like legal "strict scrutiny," parliamentary actions aim to impact the fewest people, minimizing NIMBYism and other participation barriers. This bottom-up approach prevents power centralization while enabling citizens to directly shape their communities through simple, localized solutions to pressing issues.

5. Convergence

The final principle assigns parliaments substantive responsibilities like coordinating health, education, and marketing services for their immediate areas—avoiding bureaucratic busywork. This meaningful engagement fosters community ownership and strengthens collective identity. As these self-sufficient communities develop, they naturally diminish corporate influence over local affairs.

Projects

At their seminars, Children's Parliament asks two key questions: what would the world be like if this dream gets realized, and what good aspects would be there and what evils would not be there?

Essentially their projects are on a voluntary area-to-area basis. Each area gets into contact with the broader organization. The organization gives these neighborhoods coaching and structure. Through coaching, the neighborhoods can create their own small parliaments.

Their marketing emphasizes the benefits of engagement which include but are not limited to: group therapy, healthy communication, and stronger community trust. These are all benefits that KIEZconnect values, and the experts at Children's Parliament even, "suggest that in addition to mass media which give an extensive reach to our messages, we must also organize an adequate number of groups that would discuss, decide upon, implement and ensure the continuity of the changes proposed."

Using media, Children's Parliament spreads the message of community democracy to encourage people to respond to the call to action themselves. Thus, they create a cycle of self-reported democratic health.

Success

Their international model is still based in NeighBureaucracy and focused on country-based efforts that trickle down to the neighborhoods. Over time, they have

Karin Schuster

Austria

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Thanks for this wonderful summary. It will be a long way, but every step is worth taking. We will not be discouraged, no, we go forward, step by step! For a world where everyone really matters. Sociocracy and Neighborocracy changed my life.

accrued countless testimonials that emphasize the value of providing a system that works.

People can discover the individual benefits of democracy – provided they have an intuitive framework. Showing is undoubtedly better than telling people that democracy is important and universally beneficial.

Modern Democracy

Health Status of Democracy

To understand the health of modern democracy, one must understand what healthy democracies look like. Though *FRIES* covers the necessary components of healthy democracy, it does not restrict the type of democracy it refers to. In a majority of cases, each democracy-based NGO has a different idea of what a healthy democracy looks like. Despite their different visions, they often do not discuss what type of democracy they refer to.

Some argue that modern democracy resembles an 'elite democracy' which involves a small group of wealthy and educated individuals who highly influence political decisions. Often, those who refer to modern democracy as an 'elite democracy' use the phrase negatively, as it usually signals systemic corruption.

Germany uses a parliamentary democracy for the Bundestag, wherein citizens elect a legislative parliament that selects its own leader. In Germany, that elected leader is called a chancellor.

Representative democracy is used in the U.S. and Germany. This system involves citizens electing someone to represent their interests.

Rather than these forms, this paper advocates for more direct democracy at the local level. Direct democracy is a form of democracy where citizens have the chance to vote directly on policies rather than through representatives. In all cases of successful "democracy-based" organizations, direct democracy is effectively used to prioritize local interests. Bureaucracy slows many policy decisions down, and direct democracy is notably effective at prioritizing civil interests.

Current State of Civic Engagement and Participation

Youth trust in government -

<https://www.aa.com.tr/en/europe/over-half-of-young-germans-do-not-trust-their-government-study/3129203#>

NGOs increasing since the third wave of democratization - as well as wide sentiment of cost

<https://www.cambridge.org/core/journals/international-organization/article/assault-on-civil-society-explaining-state-crackdown-on-ngos/71993D2DC576D810ADEC7675C229853B>

Pros and Cons of Normative Democracy

It would be inefficient to analyze the health status of every form of democracy, and any attempt would be hundreds of pages longer than this report. Instead, one ought to focus on the type of democracy this paper addresses at the local level, which is, of course, direct democracy. Direct democracy functions perfectly for small projects that local NGOs work on.

However, rather than implement any respective NGO's idea of what a healthy neighborhood looks like, a new and more efficient model would merely facilitate free exchange and voting.

With any recommendation for major democracy reform, one must predict the potential benefits and shortcomings.

Direct democracies are remarkably intellectually honest. Whereas in representative democracy one may vote for a person who might push a policy a citizen wants, direct democracy allows individuals to use their own voice. It also leaves little room for many of the flaws in identity politics. While direct democracies may include personality and charisma in initial presentations, they leave much less room for narratives. It is extremely difficult to characterize a wall around a park if the message is faceless. In direct democracies, interest groups replace parties and representatives. Overall, it cuts down on the psychologically damaging

confrontations in modern democracy, and leaves room for all community members to put their opinions forward.

Direct democracies also have the privilege of being extremely efficient. Citizens would immediately vote in a majority to pass or reject a plan. If rejected, a plan could be immediately thrown away since there are no political careers at stake. In an ideal framework, a legal analyst might work on the legality of a proposed plan alone, or directly with the government. Once a plan is confirmed to fit within already existing laws, the community-led process could begin.

The prior examples of democracy based NGOs prove that citizens need direct proof that democracy can work. Considering that citizens are given immediate examples of plans they introduce to the community, they are always involved in the process. Whereas suggestion boxes may be ignored or forgotten, citizens would push plans along at their own pace, which moves the labor from abstract thoughts to concrete action.

Direct democracy, similar to other forms of democracy, is largely participatory. Those who choose to participate are already engaged, this is a necessary part of a growing democracy. One cannot force a citizen to be engaged, any NGO focused on democracy must give locals a reason to trust these systems. This system would let currently engaged citizens serve as the model for others to learn from.

Direct involvement is also educational. Educational benefits apply universally to citizens. Adults could learn about civil infrastructure or communication skills. In a capitalist lens, it could also allow citizens to affect key issues that affect their property values, retirement, borrowing rates, and community. Regarding the youth, considering the recent downward trend in attention span and communication skills, this would give young people a chance to vote before the legal

age, and teach them political, communication, and networking skills. Also, anecdotes about gathering around a cause are very impressive in interviews.

While the pros are enticing, there are potential downsides to direct local democracy. In the words of Dan Kahan, Professor of Psychology at Yale Law School: "Democracy is only as effective as the education system that surrounds it." Democracy in a neighborhood setting requires a completely unbiased facilitator. If one introduces the argument that no person can possibly be unbiased, then an NGO ought to look for the closest person to an unbiased moderator. In a healthy neighborhood democracy, citizens would be subject to an inherently biased (as all humans are) moderator, and misled to believe that direct democracy is without any narrative.

Further, any organization that facilitates a direct democracy is exposed to correlation with the issues citizens vote on. While interests are brought forward by neighborhoods, facilitation is expedited by NGOs - therefore, NGOs facilitate whatever the community wants. It may make sense that if a community supports a solution, it should be carried out, though an NGO would then always be at risk of public association with a widely hated policy.

Therefore, facilitating a direct democracy has the cons of only being as effective as the education system within the neighborhood, which includes foundational flaws due to the ambiguous use of "unbiased" in any potential moderator candidate. Moreover, it would be flawed by the inherent bias in an already politically engaged person. Finally, the inherent risk of facilitating direct democracy may unfairly label an NGO with the policies of whatever neighborhood they help.

Despite all of the flaws in direct democracy, democracy is currently too large for young people.

According to the study, this is 9% higher than the average of the European countries surveyed. However, 52% of young Germans say they have no trust in the government.

When asked if they trust parliament, only 35% said "yes," 45% said "no," and 20% said "I don't know."

Young Germans have a particularly strong distrust of the media, with 60% expressing no trust in it. Multinational corporations are also viewed critically, with 53% responding negatively to a question about their trust.

The trends suggest that young people are looking for a more direct political system, one that would rely less on information from multinational corporations and media outlets. Accordingly, NGOs have followed this direction of the wave.

The dissolution of the Soviet Union and the third wave of democratization in the early 1990s gave a massive boost to the proliferation of nongovernmental organizations (NGOs) in Central and Eastern Europe. These NGOs sought to tackle a range of issues: institutional development, establishing and supporting electoral processes, and working to reduce ethnic conflict, to name a few.

As such, NGOs began to be seen in the West as a precondition for democratic transition and consolidation, protecting against authoritarian overreach and holding governments accountable.

A more direct democracy would align with democracy's natural state. While the solution isn't isolation, it's assuredly smaller than modern systems. Sometimes less is more; modern democracy is clearly shifting toward minimalism, and any NGO would benefit from staying ahead of this curve.

Effective Marketing for Local Democracy -

Any NGO that wants to convince citizens to engage might benefit from basic sales tactics. There are thousands of ways to market jobs that are generally unsavory or frustrating - and in an ideal Neighburaecracy, these would be markedly less so than in an independent NGO.

<u><i>How It Is</i></u>	<u><i>How It could be</i></u>
Thankless and frustrating	Cooperative and fulfilling!
Inefficient and difficult	A discipline development workshop!
Confrontational and inflammatory	Opportunity for trust and connection!
Upsetting and mentally-taxing	Learn negotiation strategies!
A perfect way to lose a weekend	A socially engaging event!

The most important sales tips for NGOs are: the customer is always right, everything is an opportunity not a job, and one must use 'yes and' rather than 'no but.'

The Customer is Always Right

This mantra is crucial for people in sales. Any potentially successful NGO must put members first. Decisions that favor self-interest would immediately rupture trust with locals.

Framing Opportunities

At software companies, internships are often marketed as opportunities despite commonly being unpaid and exhausting. Applicants, however, inherently understand the benefits before applying. The word 'opportunity' shifts the narrative and connotation of recruitment. Suffice to say, an NGO using this method must fully understand the context behind their marketing and outreach efforts.

The 'Yes And' Approach

Following the previously mentioned legal cooperation, a successful NGO should follow the basic rule of improvisational comedy. For example, if a citizen proposed a garden on a public sidewalk (which would constitute vandalism), a moderator might redirect by saying: "Yes, it is important for the neighborhood to have a garden, and are we sure the sidewalk is the most effective place for it?" rather than giving a blunt refusal.

Considering the modern shift toward minimalism in youth politics, non-normative, public service, democracy-based NGOs have become necessary for the public good.

Societies repeatedly experience moments of disruption that open a window for profound change.

Man is like a dog tied to a moving wagon. If the dog refuses to run along with the wagon he will be dragged by it, yet the choice remains his: to run or be dragged.

- Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations*

This paper establishes why democracy-based NGOs are ultimately destined to fail - unless we organically evolve into what public services once were.

We must shift the narrative from "service by the public" to "public service" if we hope to restore community trust. NGOs have become the replacement. It's time we start performing accordingly.

'Many forms of Government have been tried, and will be tried in this world of sin and woe.'

'No one pretends that democracy is perfect or all-wise.'

'Indeed it has been said that democracy is the worst form of Government - except for all those other forms that have been tried from time to time....'

- Winston Churchill